An Angel in Disguise

By TS Arthur

INTRODUCTION

What is compassion? By definition it is the feeling that arises when you are confronted with another's suffering and feel motivated to relieve that suffering. It's more than sending "thoughts and prayers" – it is action. Today I challenge you to reflect on the power of compassion. You may truly find . . .

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NARRATOR: **(Pg 226-243)** Idleness, vice, and intemperance had done their miserable work, and the dead mother lay cold and still amid her wretched children. This woman had been despised, scoffed at, and angrily denounced by nearly everyone in the village; but now, pity took the place of anger, and sorrow of denunciation.

Neighbors went hastily to the old tumble-down hut: some with grave-clothes for a decent interment of the body; and some with food for the half-starving children, three in number. John, the oldest, was a stout lad, able to earn his living with any farmer. Kate was a bright, active girl, out of whom something clever might be made, if in good hands; but poor little Maggie, the youngest, was hopelessly diseased. Two years before, a fall from a window had injured her spine, and she had not been able to leave her bed since.

"What is to be done with the children?" After considering the matter, farmer Jones said that he would take John, and do well by him, now that his mother was out of the way; and Mrs. Ellis concluded that it would be charitable to make choice of Katy, even though she was too young to be of much use.

MRS. ELLIS: I could do much better, I know. But as no one seems inclined to take her, I must act from a sense of duty.

NARRATOR: But no one said "I'll take Maggie." Pitying glances were cast on her wan and wasted form. The sad eyes and patient face of the little one touched many hearts. But none opened to take her in. Who wanted a bed-ridden child?

MAN 1: Take her to the poorhouse. Nobody's going to be bothered with her.

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MAN 2: The poorhouse is a sad place for a sick and helpless child.

MAN 1: For your child or mine. But for this brat it will prove a blessed change, she will be kept clean, have healthy food, and be doctored, which is more than can be said of her past condition.

NARRATOR: There was reason in that, but still it didn't satisfy. The day following the day of death was made the day of burial. A few neighbors were at the miserable hovel, but none followed dead cart as it bore the unhonored remains to its pauper grave.

Hastily others went out, some glancing at Maggie, and some resolutely refraining from a look, until all had gone. She was alone! Just beyond the threshold Joe Thompson paused, and said to the blacksmith's wife, who was hastening off with the rest . . .

JOE: It's a cruel thing to leave her so.

BLACKSMITH'S WIFE: Then take her to the poorhouse: she'll have to go there.

NARRATOR: For a little while the man stood with a puzzled air; then he turned back and went into the hovel again. Maggie with painful effort, had raised herself to an

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upright position and was sitting on the bed, straining her eyes upon the door out of which all had just departed.

MAGGIE: *(with terror in her eyes)* O, Mr. Thompson! Don't leave me here all alone!

NARRATOR: Though rough in exterior, Joe Thompson had a heart, and it was very tender in some places. He liked children and was pleased to have them come to his shop.

JOE: *(kindly)* No, dear. You sha'n't be left here alone.

NARRATOR: Then he wrapped her up in the clean bedclothes which some neighbor had brought; and, lifting her in his strong arms, bore her out into the air and across the field that lay between the hovel and his home.

Now, Joe Thompson's wife, who happened to be childless, was not a woman of saintly temper, nor much given to self-denial for others' good, saw him approaching from the window, and with ruffling feathers met him a few paces from the door.

MRS. THOMPSON: *(sharply)* What have you there?

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NARRATOR: Joe, felt the child start and shrink against him. He did not reply, except by a look that was pleading and cautionary, that said, "Wait a moment for explanations, and be gentle." He carried Maggie to the small chamber on the first floor and laid her on a bed. Then, stepping back, he shut the door, and stood face to face with his vinegar-tempered wife.

MRS. THOMPSON: *(angry and astonished)* You haven't brought home that sick brat!

NARRATOR: Usually Joe Thompson got out of his wife's way or kept rigidly silent when she fired up on any subject; it was with some surprise, therefore, that she now encountered a firmly-set countenance and a resolute pair of eyes.

JOE: *(indignantly)* Every woman at the funeral turned her eyes steadily from the sick child's face, and when the cart went off with her dead mother, hurried away, and left her alone in that old hut.

MRS. THOMPSON: Where were John and Kate?

JOE: Farmer Jones tossed John into his wagon and drove off. Katie went home with Mrs. Ellis; but nobody

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wanted the poor sick one. 'Send her to the poorhouse,' was the cry.

MRS. THOMPSON: Why didn't you let her go, then. What did you bring her here?

JOE: She can't walk to the poorhouse. Somebody's arms must carry her, and mine are strong enough for that task. The Guardians must be seen, and a permit obtained . . Tomorrow.

MRS. THOMPSON: Why put it off till tomorrow? Go at once for the permit and get the whole thing off your hands tonight.

JOE: *(voice shaking with emotion)* Jane, I read the Bible sometimes, and find much said about little children. How the Savior rebuked the disciples who would not receive them; how he took them up in his arms and blessed them; and how he said that 'whosoever gave them even a cup of cold water should not go unrewarded.' Now, it is a small thing for us to keep this poor motherless little one for a single night; to be kind to her for a single night.

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NARRATOR: He turned his head away, so that the moisture in his eyes might not be seen. Mrs. Thompson did not answer, but a soft feeling crept into her heart.

JOE: *(softly)* Look at her kindly, Jane; speak to her kindly. Think of her dead mother, and the loneliness, the pain, the sorrow that must be on all her coming life.

NARRATOR: Mrs. Thompson did not reply, but presently turned towards the little chamber where her husband had deposited Maggie; and, pushing open the door, went quietly in. Joe did not follow; he saw that her state had changed and felt that it would be best to leave her alone with the child. So he went to his shop and worked until dusky evening released him from labor.

After washing from his hands and face the dust and soil of work, Joe went to the little bedroom. A pair of large bright eyes looked up at him from the bed; looked at him tenderly, gratefully, pleadingly. How his heart swelled! Joe sat down, and now, for the first time, examining the thin frame carefully under the lamp light, saw that it was an attractive face, and full of

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a childish sweetness which suffering had not been able to obliterate.

JOE: Your name is Maggie?

MAGGIE: *(voice quivering)* Yes, sir.

JOE: Have you been sick long? Has the doctor been to see you?

MAGGIE: He used to come.

JOE: But not lately . . . Have you any pain?

MAGGIE: This morning my side ached, and my back hurt when you carried me. But it hasn't ached any since I've been on this soft bed.

JOE: The soft bed feels good.

MAGGIE: *(gratitude in her voice)* O, yes, sir--so good!

MRS. THOMPSON: *(looking into the room)* Supper is ready. *(feigning indifference)* ***She*** can wait until we are done; then I will bring her somethings to eat.

NARRATOR: After sitting down to the table, Joe waited for his wife to introduce the subject uppermost in both of their thoughts; but she kept silent for many minutes.

MRS. THOMPSON: *(abruptly)* What are you going to do with ***that child***?

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JOE: *(surprised)* I thought you understood that she was to go to the poorhouse.

NARRATOR: Mrs. Thompson looked rather strangely at her husband, and then dropped her eyes. The subject was not again referred to during the meal. At its close, Mrs. Thompson toasted a slice of bread, and softened, it with milk and butter; adding to this a cup of tea, she took them into Maggie. The hungry child ate with every sign of pleasure.

MRS. THOMPSON: Is it good?

NARRATOR: The child paused with the cup in her hand and answered with a look of gratitude that awoke to new life old human feelings which had been slumbering in her heart for half a score of years.

NARRATOR: At breakfast-time on the next morning . . .

JOE: [I] must step down and see the Guardians of the Poor about Maggie.

MRS. THOMPSON: *(matter-of-factly)* We'll keep her a day or two longer; she is so weak and helpless.

JOE: She'll be so much in your way.

MRS. THOMPSON: I sha'n't mind that for a day or two. Poor thing!

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NARRATOR: Joe did not see the Guardians of the Poor on that day, on the next. In fact, he never saw them at all on Maggie's account, for in less than a week Mrs. Joe Thompson would as soon leave thought of taking up her own abode in the almshouse as sending Maggie there.

What light and blessing did that sick and helpless child bring to the home of Joe Thompson! It had been dark, and cold, and miserable there for a long time just because his wife had nothing to love and care for. [But now] An angel had come into [their] house, disguised as a helpless child, and filled all its dreary chambers with the sunshine of love.

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AWARD HISTORY

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